47TH ANNIVERSARY



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A Fairytale Christmas

Christianity was first introduced to India in 52 CE by none other than the apostle Thomas, who landed on the Malabar coast to spread the gospel. Two millennia on, there are Christmas celebrations across India—including a moving midnight mass at San Thome Basilica in Mylapore, Chennai, which still holds a few of St Thomas's srelics.

The city that goes to town with Christmas is Kolkata, from midnight mass at St Paul's Cathedral to carol singing, plum cakes and much merrymaking. The **Park Street Christmas Festival** sees the entire road lit up with fairy lights. There's a giant Christmas tree for those Insta-worthy shots and even a Christmas Parade. The special Christmas menu at Flury's is not to be missed. Equally festive are the Bow Barracks, home to the city's Anglo-Indian community.

Goa, with its plethora of beautiful churches, is another hotspot, and the year-end holiday destination of choice. The Basilica of Bom Jesus in Old Goa is a must-visit on Christmas, as is the Latin Quarter of **Fontainhas** in Panjim. In Mumbai, the 'village' of Matharpacady or Mazagon is home to the East Indian Catholic community and sees traditional Christmas festivities. For a Northeastern twist to Christmas, don't miss Meghalaya's capital Shillong. It's home to the world-famous **Shillong Chamber Choir** and you wouldn't want to miss their soulful hymn singing.

Such a Long Journey

Come January and the world's longest river cruise will chug off on its 4,000 km journey from the holy city of Varanasi. The **Ganga Vilas Cruise**, being operated by Antara Cruises, will travel from Varanasi to Dibrugarh, via Kolkata and Dhaka.

Sarbananda Sonowal, the Union minister of ports, shipping and waterways, announced the cruise recently. The riverine journey will last a total of 50 days, cover 27 river systems and more than 50 tourist sites, including several World Heritage Sites, revealed the minister. The cruise will also take in the spectacular natural vistas of the

